



CAPITAL REGION

Eastern Greenway

A regional planning and policy framework for mobility, conservation, and deliberate growth east of Meridian Township

THE PROPOSITION

Meet today's mobility needs while permanently protecting green space and incorporating recreation, non-motorized transportation, wildlife continuity, and water management from the beginning.

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CONCEPT PAPER

Not an engineering design, route determination, environmental document, cost estimate, or legal opinion.

EXECUTIVE PROPOSITION

A green edge that carries regional movement

The Capital Region Eastern Greenway is a planning framework for a limited-access, four-lane expressway and conservation corridor linking I-69 and I-96 east of Haslett and Okemos. It is not a proposal to complete a conventional beltway or build the first stage of a future freeway. It is intended to move traffic and meet present community needs while permanently preserving green space and incorporating recreation, non-motorized transportation, habitat continuity, and water protection from the beginning. The harder problem is how to deliver that regional movement without using a new road to license the next wave of diffuse, infrastructure-intensive sprawl.

The timing matters. Meridian Charter Township grew from 39,688 residents in 2010 to 43,916 in 2020, an increase of about 10.7 percent; the Census Bureau's 2025 estimate is 44,869.³ The Township's own planning documents pair focused development with natural-resource preservation, and its parks plan reports substantial public, quasi-public, and millage-preserved open space.⁴⁵ East of Meridian, however, the agricultural and ecological landscape remains coherent enough to shape before parcel fragmentation makes both transportation and preservation dramatically harder.

ONE DECISION BEFORE CONCRETE

The first public action should be a regional feasibility and corridor-preservation study—not authorization to build a road. Land-use commitments, access rules, conservation tools, and performance measures must be designed before capacity is added.

The integrated proposition

The Greenway would combine a two-lane-per-direction expressway, strict access management, a wide future transit and managed-flex reserve, a separated regional trail, roadside recovery and runoff zones, naturalized stormwater treatment, wildlife crossings, agricultural and habitat conservation easements, and compact development nodes at a small number of major crossings.

Its defining idea is not that every component is novel. The innovation is institutional and spatial: transportation, permanent land preservation, drainage, recreation, non-motorized and transit readiness, habitat continuity, and development policy are treated as one corridor program rather than as separate projects competing for leftover space. The conservation and access interests must be acquired, recorded, funded, and assigned to a responsible steward as part of the original project; they are not landscaping or mitigation to be value-engineered later.

ROAD FORM	Limited-access rural/suburban expressway; two through lanes in each direction; major junctions selectively at grade.
GROWTH FORM	A moderately permeable regional edge: compact planned nodes, protected land between them, and no continuous frontage development.
LAND STRATEGY	Public right-of-way only where needed; adjacent land may remain privately owned under voluntary or acquired conservation/development-rights controls, subject to lawful authority.
SUCCESS TEST	Safer, reliable movement; less pressure on Marsh Road and US-127; permanent land protection; stronger trail/transit links; no unmanaged sprawl.

HISTORY AND INSTITUTIONAL LESSON

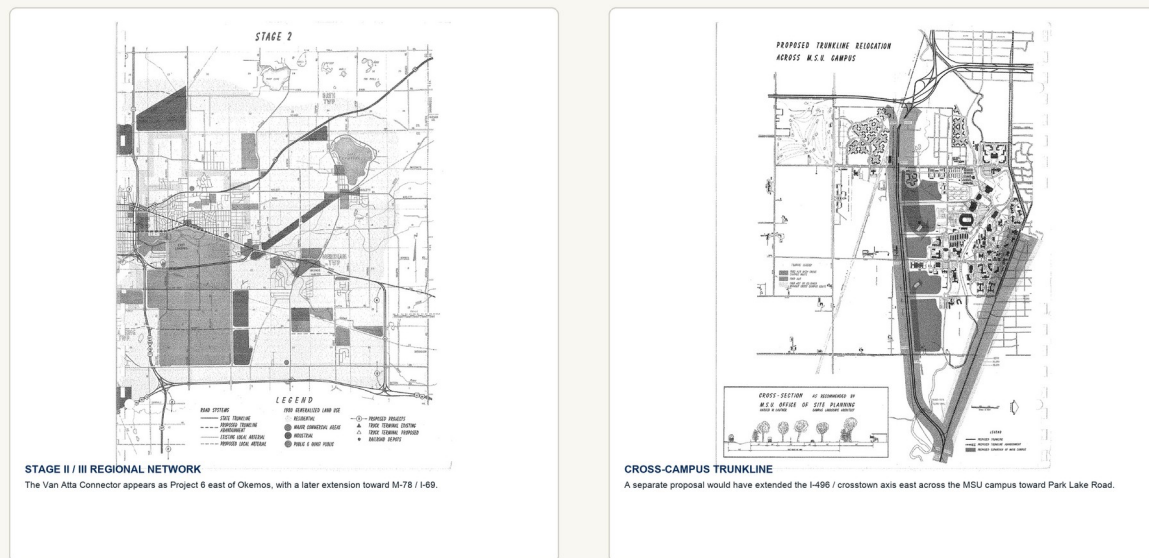
The unfinished network—and the cost of the old doctrine

The Greenway begins with history, but it does not attempt to revive the 1961 plan. The Michigan State Highway Department's Lansing Area Trunkline Plan proposed an internal crosstown system, the I-496 urban loop, a route across the Michigan State University campus, and a Van Atta Connector from I-96 to then-US-16/Grand River Avenue, later extending north toward M-78 and the future I-69 corridor.¹ The Van Atta project was meant to serve anticipated subdivision growth and to help define the perimeter within which the plan expected most physical growth to occur.

The same report captured the era's hierarchy in a seven-word maxim: "transportation comes first—and always first."¹ That premise delivered mobility, but it treated communities, landscape, and social needs as variables to be adjusted around a road plan. The consequences are clearest in I-496.

THE 1961 LANSING AREA TRUNKLINE VISION

A freeway-era plan that shaped the region - and left major projects unbuilt



Source: Michigan State Highway Department, Lansing Area Trunkline Plan (September 1961), MDOT Research Report RR-93.

Figure 1. The freeway-era regional vision contained both the Van Atta and cross-campus concepts. *The images are reproduced from MDOT Research Report RR-93; annotations are Cognisint's.*

A different historical response

The lesson is not that regional mobility is illegitimate. It is that route, section, access policy, land acquisition, and governance determine what mobility infrastructure does to the place around it. The Greenway therefore reverses the ordering rule: transportation is one necessary public function within a larger civic landscape.

I-496 AND HISTORICAL LOSS

What the freeway erased

By the early 1960s, the Main Street–St. Joseph corridor was the residential, commercial, and institutional heart of Lansing’s largest Black neighborhood. Restrictive covenants, discriminatory lending, and real-estate practices had constrained where Black families could buy or rent; within those constraints, residents built a durable community of homes, churches, schools, social clubs, and businesses serving customers who were excluded elsewhere.² Main Street—now Malcolm X Street—was therefore not simply a collection of parcels in a proposed right-of-way. It was an economic and social network.

Construction of I-496 began in 1963. The Historical Society of Greater Lansing reports that more than 800 homes and businesses stood in the proposed corridor and that 35 streets were dead-ended.² Michigan Public reports that federal acquisition displaced more than 650 Black families.²⁰ The figures use different units and source records, but they describe the same event: a concentrated community was dispersed into a housing market that still restricted where many displaced residents could go.

PEOPLE	Families lost proximity to relatives, neighbors, schools, churches, clubs, and informal support networks that compensation schedules could not replace.
COMMERCE	Black-owned and Black-serving businesses lost both premises and the nearby customer base that made Main Street a functioning commercial district.
URBAN FABRIC	Thirty-five dead-ended streets, ramps, one-way conversions, and the freeway trench weakened movement between downtown, the South Side, and REO Town.
HISTORICAL RECORD	Demolition removed the physical settings through which Lansing’s Black history and working-class automotive history had been made visible.

The Ransom E. Olds mansion

The freeway also consumed a prominent civic landmark at Washington Avenue and Main Street: the 1902 Ransom E. Olds mansion. Gladys Olds Anderson donated the house in 1966 for preservation. The Historical Society of Michigan and the State Highway Department cooperated on a plan to move it, but only about 70 percent of the needed \$100,000 had been raised when the building was razed.¹⁹ The road was later named for Olds. That irony should not eclipse the far greater human burden imposed on the Black neighborhood, but it makes the historical lesson unusually concrete: freeway construction erased both an irreplaceable community landscape and a landmark associated with the industrial history used to justify Lansing’s growth.

THE INSTITUTIONAL LESSON

Property acquisition can compensate recognized interests in land. It cannot by itself re-create a neighborhood economy, restore severed social relationships, or recover demolished history. Those losses must enter route selection before a preferred alternative is chosen.

MAIN STREET, MEMORY, AND UNEQUAL POWER

The landscape before the trench

A particularly revealing pre-freeway photograph appears in the December 5, 2018 issue of *City Pulse*: an undated view looking north along Logan Street—now Martin Luther King Jr. Boulevard—across Main Street and St. Joseph Highway. Its roadside signs, small businesses, ordinary traffic, sidewalks, houses, and intersecting streets show a place that was somewhat worn but unmistakably active.³⁰ The image matters because clearance photographs and aerial plans can make the corridor look empty before construction. It was not empty. It was lived in.



Figure 2. Logan Street looking north across Main Street and St. Joseph Highway before I-496. *The lively traffic corridor is flanked by Standard service-station signs, homes, businesses, sidewalks, and utility infrastructure. Undated photograph published in City Pulse, December 5, 2018, p. 12; original photographer and rights holder are not identified in the page caption.*

This is the landscape the freeway-era plans reduced to a line on a map. Its congestion and modest buildings do not make it disposable; they demonstrate that Main Street was already a functioning urban place whose homes, commerce, institutions, and daily movement were intertwined.

BUILT THROUGH MAIN STREET; STOPPED AT MSU

Two corridors, unequal power

The 1961 trunkline plan treated I-496 and the cross-campus freeway as parts of one connected system. The proposed campus route would have continued the Main Street axis east from the Trowbridge–Harrison area, generally along the railroad corridor, toward Grand River Avenue and Park Lake Road.¹ At that stage Michigan State University tentatively supported the route and indicated willingness to provide right-of-way.

Hannah left the presidency in 1969. In 1971, after sustained student, faculty, neighborhood, and municipal opposition, the MSU Board of Trustees rejected the route; East Lansing also withdrew support.²⁸ The decisive contrast is institutional. MSU controlled a consolidated campus, possessed a constitutionally powerful governing board, could mobilize professional and student constituencies, and dealt with the state as a major institution. Hannah’s long presidency had made MSU nationally prominent and politically connected through his service in federal defense, civil-rights, and foreign-assistance roles.²⁹ Black residents and merchants along Main Street—already constrained by discriminatory housing and credit systems—had no comparable landholding institution, governing board, or practical veto.

MAIN STREET / I-496	A predominantly Black neighborhood, commercial district, churches, schools, and social networks were acquired and dispersed. Opposition could be heard, but no institution in the corridor could withhold the route.
MSU CROSS-CAMPUS ROUTE	The University and East Lansing could reverse earlier support, organize opposition, and stop the route before construction crossed the campus.
HISTORICAL CONCLUSION	Engineering need did not alone determine which landscape was sacrificed. Unequal political and institutional power shaped which community could force reconsideration.

CHRONOLOGY AND ACCOUNTABILITY

It would be inaccurate to credit Hannah personally with the 1971 veto. It is accurate—and important—to say that the politically formidable university built during his presidency possessed leverage that Black Main Street did not.

The road not built

Today the western approach to the canceled alignment is the comparatively tranquil, landscaped Trowbridge Road entrance between I-496, Harrison Road, and Farm Lane. It uses at-grade intersections, separated paths, green setbacks, selective access, and a clear transition into campus. Trowbridge is not a direct prototype for a regional expressway, but it is a local reminder that efficient movement need not require a continuous freeway trench.

CORRIDOR CONCEPT

An eastern alignment that follows existing structure

The concept shifts east of the historic Van Atta corridor because development in Meridian Township has made that older alignment costly, disruptive, and poorly suited to a growth-edge function. The definitive route map establishes the proposal's planning geography between the developed edge of Haslett and Okemos and the Williamston area. Much of the alignment—particularly its southern half—does not occupy an existing road. It follows farm-property lines through land that is now fields rather than public roadway.

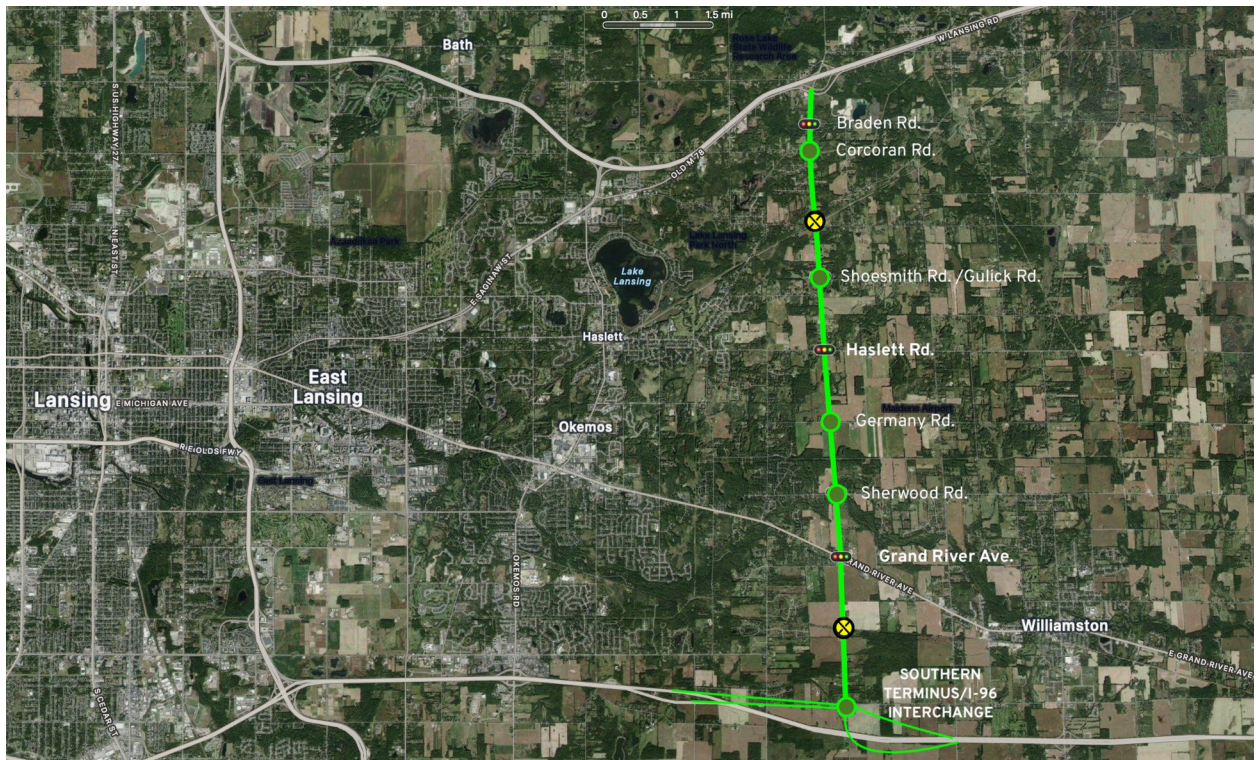


Figure 3. Definitive conceptual route map supplied by the proposal's author. The highlighted alignment and junction symbols establish the proposal's planning concept; they do not represent a surveyed centerline, approved traffic-control plan, or engineering design.

Planning-level route narrative

The definitive concept begins at the I-69 interface in the Braden–Corcoran Road area. It continues south through a signalized Braden Road junction and a Corcoran Road roundabout, crosses the railroad north of Shoesmith/Gulick, and uses a roundabout at Shoesmith Road/Gulick Road. Farther south, the concept shows a signalized Haslett Road junction, roundabouts at Germany and Sherwood Roads, and a signalized Grand River Avenue junction. The alignment then crosses the railroad south of Grand River Avenue and enters the illustrated compact I-96 terminus/interchange.

The concept has only two grade-separated roadway junctions: the northern I-69 terminus and the southern I-96 terminus. Every intermediate road junction shown on the route map remains at grade, using signals or roundabouts as indicated; other at-grade forms could be evaluated during design. Minor roads would not automatically receive crossings. The Red Cedar River requires a new bridge, but that structure is a water crossing rather than a grade-separated intersection. For planning and cost purposes, the two railroad crossings should be assumed to use grade separation—most likely roadway flyovers—unless railroad coordination and engineering analysis establish a better treatment.

DEFINING THE TYPOLOGY

How to read the road vocabulary

Transportation terms describe different things: legal access rights, physical design, network function, and traffic control. They are often used interchangeably in public debate even though they are not interchangeable. The distinctions below follow MDOT road terminology and FHWA's access-and-mobility hierarchy, while stating explicitly how this paper uses each term.²¹²²

THE DISTINCTION MICHIGAN READERS MAY NOT EXPECT

Two separate questions are often collapsed into one. Access control asks whether adjoining parcels receive driveways or frontage connections. Grade separation asks whether public roads meet at the same elevation. The Greenway prohibits direct parcel access, so it is limited access; it retains selected at-grade public-road intersections, so it is not a fully controlled-access freeway. Michigan law and historical usage sometimes blur these categories, but the project depends on keeping them distinct.

Access control: who may connect, and where

ACCESS REGIME	PHYSICAL CONSEQUENCE	GREENWAY APPLICATION
Full control	No direct property access. Entry, exit, and transfer occur by ramps; crossroads pass over or under.	Reserved for the I-69 and I-96 termini and any location where later analysis proves full separation necessary.
Limited or partial control	Driveways are prohibited or exceptional, but selected public-road intersections may remain at grade.	The proposed corridor form: a small number of planned, durable crossing nodes separated by long access-controlled segments.
Access management	Spacing, medians, shared access, turn restrictions, and local land-use rules manage conflict on roads that still serve property.	A supporting policy for intersecting roads and growth nodes; it is not equivalent to acquiring legal access rights.

Road type and network function

TERM	CORE IDEA	RELATION TO THE GREENWAY
Freeway	A divided arterial with full access control and grade-separated crossings.	Not the proposed intermediate corridor form.
Expressway	A high-mobility roadway with limited or partial access control. Unlike a freeway, it may include selected at-grade intersections.	The proposed Greenway form: divided, limited access, and selectively at grade. Contrary to historical usage in Michigan and some other states, this paper does not treat freeway and expressway as the same thing.
Arterial	A functional class emphasizing longer trips and regional mobility; it may be a freeway, expressway, or conventional highway.	The Greenway would function as a principal arterial.
Collector	A road that gathers traffic from local roads and distributes it to arterials.	Existing collectors should connect at selected nodes without becoming continuous frontage routes.
Stroad	Planning shorthand—not an official functional class—for a corridor that tries to combine high-speed movement with dense property access.	The Greenway is NOT a stroad. Continuous frontage, dense driveway access, strip development, and accumulated turning conflicts are incompatible with the proposal.

SELECTIVE PERMEABILITY

At grade, grade separated, and deliberately connected

Access control does not answer every intersection question. A crossing may merely pass over or under the Greenway, or it may allow traffic to transfer. At-grade intersections can be signalized or unsignalized, and several geometric families can relocate or remove the most hazardous turning conflicts. MDOT and FHWA guidance distinguish median U-turns, RCUTs, roundabouts, and other alternatives by the movements they relocate or eliminate—not by their visual resemblance.²³²⁴²⁵

AT-GRADE INTERSECTION	Roads meet at the same elevation. Movements conflict in shared space and are assigned by signals, stop control, yield control, or geometric priority.
GRADE SEPARATION	One route passes over or under another. If no ramps connect them, it is a crossing—not an interchange.
INTERCHANGE	A grade-separated junction with ramps that permit traffic to transfer between routes. Full access control depends on interchanges rather than at-grade intersections.

Intersection-control families

FORM	HOW MOVEMENT IS ASSIGNED	POTENTIAL GREENWAY ROLE
Conventional signal	Traffic signals assign right-of-way by phase; direct left and through movements may be permitted.	Major nodes where traffic, trail crossings, transit, and pedestrian demand justify positive control.
Stop- or yield-controlled	Signs assign priority without a traffic signal; suitability depends on speed, visibility, and traffic balance.	Low-volume local connections only if the safety analysis supports them.
Modern roundabout	Entering traffic yields to counterclockwise circulating traffic; geometry creates low-speed deflection.	A major-node option where continuous low-speed operation and safe crossing design can be achieved.
Michigan Left / median U-turn	Direct left turns are relocated to downstream median crossovers; the main intersection may be signalized or unsignalized.	A possible access-management tool, but not a default and not a freeway treatment.
RCUT / J-turn	Minor-road left and through movements first turn right, then use a downstream U-turn; major-road movements may remain direct.	A possible rural treatment for lower-volume crossroads, with pedestrian and freight effects studied explicitly.
Other alternatives	RIRO, high-T, displaced-left, quadrant-roadway, and related forms remove, relocate, or simplify selected conflicts.	A screening set for later engineering—not a menu of predetermined features.

THE OPERATING PRINCIPLE

A freeway separates nearly every crossing. A stroad accumulates conflicts until access defeats movement. The Greenway preserves mobility through a small, evidence-based set of durable crossing forms, with safe pedestrian and wildlife passages designed as part of the same system.

THE PHYSICAL FRAMEWORK

A physical framework organized by functions, not leftovers

The principal conceptual cross section shows an approximately 384-foot total corridor envelope: about 284 feet of constructed and managed corridor plus 100 feet of flanking conservation land. Much of that protected land could remain privately owned under development-rights, conservation, view, and access controls. The dimensions organize the concept; they are not survey or design values and must be rebuilt through professional safety, drainage, environmental, geotechnical, operational, and property analysis.

INTEGRATED GREENWAY TRANSPORTATION CORRIDOR – CROSS SECTION

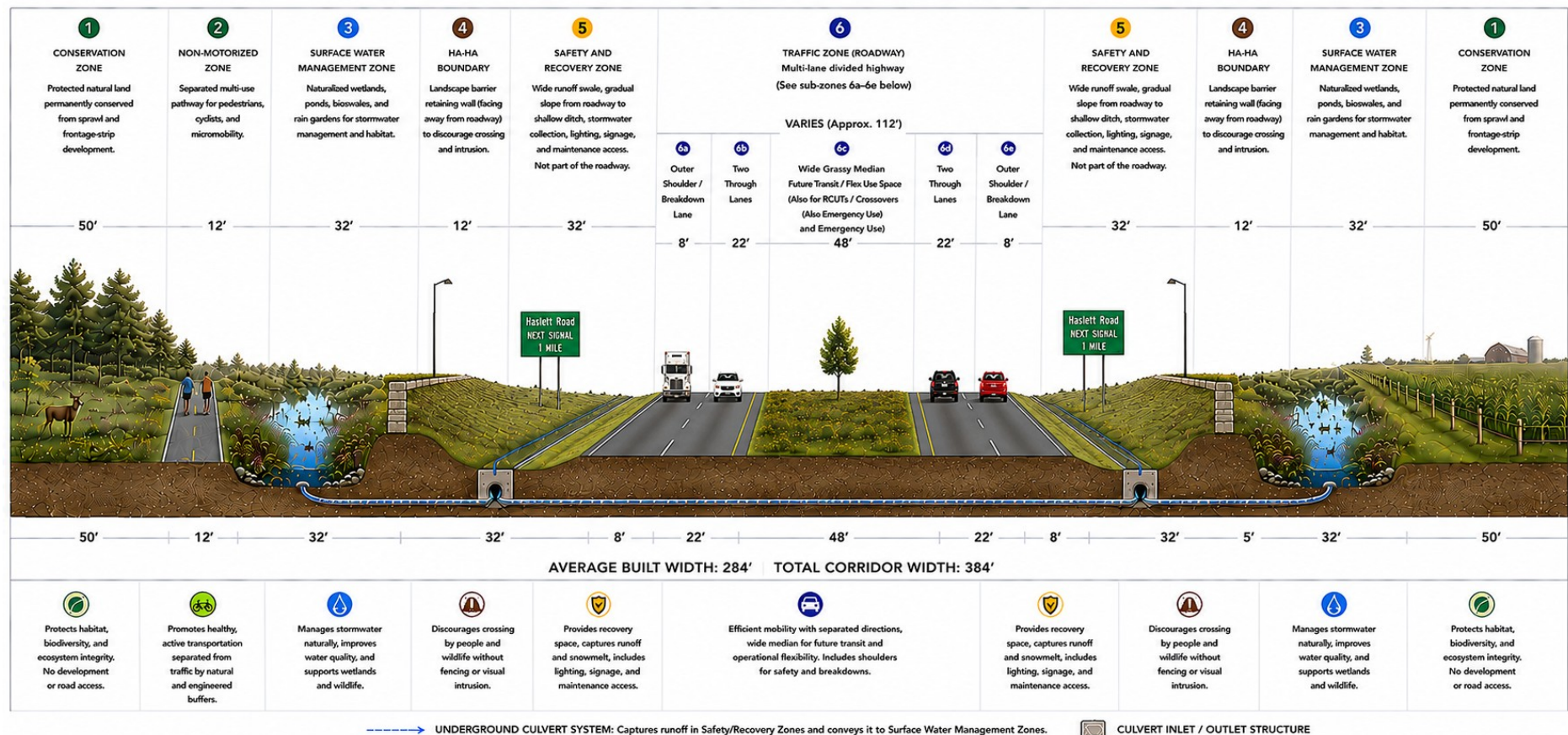


Figure 4. Principal conceptual cross section. This is the most complete statement of the proposed lateral sequence, approximate widths, one-sided non-motorized zone, surface-water treatment, outward-facing ha-ha boundaries, roadside recovery areas, four through lanes, wide median reserve, and culvert connections. Conceptual planning illustration—not an engineering drawing.

THE PHYSICAL FRAMEWORK

Open landscape without development frontage

The aerial illustrates the Greenway's regional bargain. It preserves open land and natural surface-water disposition while moving traffic efficiently, but it does not convert adjoining acreage into commercial or residential highway frontage. Land beside the corridor may remain physically capable of development, yet direct access is unavailable: no driveways, no continuous frontage roads, and no implied entitlement to a new intersection. That absence of parcel access is what makes the corridor limited access. The presence of selected at-grade public-road intersections is what keeps it from being a fully controlled-access freeway. Together with the preservation zone, that combination separates mobility investment from ribbon development and helps prevent the roadway from becoming an engine of sprawl.



Figure 5. Photorealistic visualization of the Greenway's landscape and access strategy. *Open space remains open; naturalized wetlands and runoff systems remain legible; traffic moves through selected at-grade nodes; and adjoining land gains no direct frontage access. At this aerial scale, the roadway side of the ha-ha reads as a continuous grassy rise, while Figure 6 provides the closer explanation of its outward-facing edge.*

The lateral sequence

From the protected landscape inward, a trail and linear park occupy one side of the corridor. A naturalized surface-water zone follows, then the abrupt landscape-facing ha-ha edge. A separate safety and runoff zone provides recovery space, snow storage, information and lighting locations, and a shallow ditch that directs water through controlled culverts to the treatment landscape. Only after that zone ends does the paved shoulder and traffic realm begin.

The median is intentionally wide but not paved as a third travel lane. Native plantings occur in clumps, preserving visibility and maintenance access. Unobstructed margins at its edges reserve a future choice: bus rapid transit, high-occupancy or managed operation, emergency use, or another mobility technology supported by evidence at the time.

LANDSCAPE ACCESS AND ENVIRONMENTAL SYSTEMS

Separation without rupture



Figure 6. Photorealistic concept of the outward-facing ha-ha edge. This close-range image, rather than the aerial overview, shows the intended asymmetric relationship: the abrupt wall face is visible from the trail and water-management side while the roadway side reads as gradual landform. Conceptual only; final geometry requires tested roadside-safety, accessibility, drainage, and wildlife design.

A traditional ha-ha is a concealed ditch and retaining wall developed to keep livestock out of a designed landscape while preserving an uninterrupted view across it.²⁶ The Greenway adapts that asymmetric idea: the short, abrupt face is visible from the conservation, water, and trail side, where a clear boundary is needed, while the roadway side rises gradually and remains visually open. It is not merely a subtle grade change, and it must not turn the road into a trench.

PEOPLE	The abrupt outer edge discourages casual entry and guides trail users toward designated, accessible crossings. Fall protection, maintenance access, emergency egress, and human behavior still require professional design.
ANIMALS	The edge can act as a guidance feature, directing deer and other terrestrial animals toward mapped underpasses or overpasses. Species that can jump, climb, burrow, or fly may require additional measures.
SIGHTLINES	The one-sided vertical break preserves long views from the roadway and across open land while making the restricted edge legible at close range from the landscape side.
SOUND	Coordinated landform can interrupt or lengthen the sound path and create an acoustic shadow. A low ha-ha alone is not a presumed noise barrier; effectiveness depends on height, continuity, source and receiver elevations, and formal modeling.

WATER, WILDLIFE, AND ROADSIDE SAFETY**A linked system, not a decorative edge**

FHWA recognizes earth berms and walls as noise barriers when they are high and continuous enough to break the line of sight between traffic and a receiver.²⁷ That supports the use of landform as part of the acoustic strategy, but it does not justify promising a particular reduction from the ha-ha section without a project-specific noise study.

The adjacent recovery ditch performs different work. It must slow or contain an errant vehicle, collect rain and snowmelt, support maintenance, and avoid creating a ramp toward the ha-ha or trail. The ditch and ha-ha may reinforce each other, but neither receives safety credit until roadside-safety, geotechnical, drainage, accessibility, and wildlife specialists validate the section.

ROADSIDE RECOVERY	Shallow recovery geometry must safely decelerate or redirect errant vehicles and must not form a launch ramp toward the ha-ha or trail.
WATER TRANSFER	Dedicated culverts carry captured runoff beneath the ha-ha into naturalized treatment cells. Outlets must avoid erosion, standing-water hazards, and wildlife traps.
WILDLIFE GUIDANCE	Edge treatments guide rather than guarantee movement toward mapped passages. Species and site conditions govern passage dimensions, spacing, and any supplemental fencing.
HUMAN CROSSINGS	Trail users cross only at accessible, conspicuous, protected locations integrated with signals, underpasses, or overpasses as context requires.

Wildlife continuity should be mapped before a centerline is selected. Michigan DNR guidance emphasizes avoiding severed natural-cover corridors and aligning passages with wetlands, streams, hedgerows, and existing movement patterns.¹⁴ A frequent-crossing premise may be tested in sensitive segments, but spacing and dimensions must be species- and site-specific; fencing or other measures may still be necessary. The adjoining water landscape is equally functional: EGLE requires avoidance, minimization, and mitigation of regulated impacts, while MDOT already treats stormwater pollutant reduction as an operating responsibility.¹⁵¹⁸

DEMAND, ACCESS, AND LAND USE**Design against induced demand—before opening day**

Induced demand is not a slogan and it is not limited to a driver choosing a faster route. FHWA defines it as traffic drawn to new or expanded capacity through route shifts, discretionary trips, and changed access to jobs and other activities.⁶ Duranton and Turner found that vehicle travel in U.S. metropolitan areas rose roughly in proportion to interstate lane supply over time, with additional driving associated with current residents, transportation-intensive activity, and population change.⁷

The Greenway cannot abolish that response. It can, however, refuse to amplify it through uncontrolled land entitlement. The anti-sprawl mechanism is therefore a binding package, not a landscaped cross-section: access rights secured with the corridor; permanent preservation agreements in the buffer; node-based zoning and infrastructure boundaries adopted before construction; no continuous frontage; no speculative interchange districts; and public reporting on development, traffic, mode share, conserved acreage, and infrastructure obligations.

Access management is essential to that package. FHWA describes it as the proactive management of parcel access to preserve roadway safety, capacity, and speed; its techniques include wider signal and driveway spacing, indirect left turns, U-turns, and roundabouts.⁸ The Greenway uses these tools to control conflict and development response, not merely to move more vehicles.

A moderately permeable edge

The corridor is not a hard urban growth boundary. It is a structured border. Urban and suburban development would be favored primarily to the west; agriculture, habitat, and open space would dominate to the east. Planned nodes at major crossings could accommodate housing, employment, services, park access, and mobility hubs at an intensity capable of supporting infrastructure. Between nodes, the landscape remains continuous.

This is smart growth in the fiscally literal sense. EPA's review of scenario-planning evidence concludes that compact development generally requires less road, water, and sewer infrastructure than dispersed growth.⁹ The objective is not to deny rural jurisdictions development or tax base, but to locate growth where its long-run service obligations are supportable.

FARMLAND, GREENBELT, AND DEVELOPMENT RIGHTS

Keep working land working—and on the tax roll

Michigan already recognizes farmland and open-space preservation as public policy. The Farmland and Open Space Preservation Program—commonly called PA 116 and now codified in Part 361 of the Natural Resources and Environmental Protection Act—uses development restrictions and tax incentives to keep qualifying land in agricultural use.¹² It should be treated as one tool in a larger corridor program, not as shorthand for every easement the project may need.

Ann Arbor's Greenbelt demonstrates a complementary model. Its conservation easements pay landowners for permanent restrictions while land remains privately owned; the easement value reflects the difference between development potential and restricted agricultural or conservation value.¹⁰¹¹ The program has preserved thousands of acres through local funding, grants, donations, and intergovernmental partnerships.

A Capital Region program could combine voluntary PA 116 participation, locally purchased agricultural conservation easements, conservation easements held by qualified entities, fee-simple acquisition for public trail or habitat assets, targeted access-right acquisition, and transfer-of-development-rights mechanisms where local law and market conditions support them.

Control frontage without taking the farm

Where the new alignment runs along farm-property lines, the responsible highway authority would acquire the limited-access rights needed to prohibit direct frontage connections while leaving the adjoining farm in private ownership. The owner would retain the frontage property, subject to the compensated access restriction and any separately acquired conservation or development-rights interest. Paired with the Greenway's preservation zone, that structure prevents the new road from converting working fields into developable highway frontage: the land is protected, and the road supplies no driveway access to it.

LEGAL AND GOVERNANCE CAVEAT

This paper does not assume that MDOT can condemn broad development rights for general growth control. The responsible next step is a Michigan-specific authority analysis defining which entity may acquire which interest, for what public purpose, under what process, with what compensation and long-term stewardship obligation.

Preserve blocks, not fragments

The preservation strategy should prioritize contiguous agricultural and ecological systems, not a uniform decorative strip. Wider acquisitions or easements may be justified around wetlands, woodlots, tributaries, wildlife crossings, scenic views, trailheads, and productive farm blocks. Narrower controls may be sufficient where parcel access is already constrained. The corridor width is therefore a programmatic envelope, not a constant taking line.

MOBILITY BEYOND THE AUTOMOBILE

Build the missing eastern spine into an existing network

Greater Lansing is not starting from zero. Tri-County Regional Planning Commission's 2023 Regional Trails Feasibility Plan identified more than 75 miles of potential connections between the Lansing River Trail system and the Clinton-Ionia-Shiawassee, Mike Levine Lakelands, and Paul Henry-Thornapple trails.¹³ Ingham County, Meridian Township, and regional partners have already treated trail connectivity as transportation and quality-of-life infrastructure.

The Greenway trail should therefore be planned as a regional facility, not a recreational appendage. It would connect parks, rural communities, future mobility hubs, the Red Cedar corridor, and existing or planned pathways. Its alignment may curve independently around wetlands and landscape features. Safe crossings should be grade separated where exposure warrants it and integrated with signalized node crossings where that produces a better network.

Transit readiness without empty pavement

The center reserve protects a future transit option without building an underused transitway on day one. Initial service could be regional express bus operating in the general lanes, with mobility hubs at I-69, M-43, and I-96. Stops belong at designed pullouts or station areas within the vehicular zone—not in the recovery ditch and not as a continuous sidewalk condition along the outer shoulder.

Conversion of median margins to managed or transit use should require a published threshold: demonstrated demand, an operating and maintenance commitment, safe station access, and evidence that the change advances regional goals rather than simply becoming a third general-purpose lane.

Freight and commerce

Freight remains a legitimate purpose. A reliable I-69/I-96 connection may improve network resilience and divert some regional trips away from Marsh Road, central US-127, and built-up Meridian corridors. But that effect must be modeled rather than promised. The feasibility study should distinguish diverted through trips, new trips, node-generated trips, and changes in local travel behavior, and it should test transit and demand-management alternatives alongside the roadway concept.

GOVERNANCE AND DELIVERY

No single agency should own the whole idea

The corridor crosses institutional boundaries by design. A credible sponsor must be able to hold transportation, land use, conservation, water, parks, transit, and property rights in the same decision structure. Tri-County Regional Planning Commission is a logical convener for an initial study because it already coordinates metropolitan transportation and regional trail planning; it need not become the eventual owner.

PARTNER GROUP	CORE ROLE	EARLY DECISION
MDOT + FHWA	System planning, access control, interstate connections, safety and federal process	Whether a state trunkline concept warrants alternatives analysis
Townships, counties, City of Williamston	Land use, infrastructure boundaries, nodes, local roads, public legitimacy	Whether binding growth and frontage rules can precede construction
MDARD + land-preservation partners	PA 116, purchased easements, farm viability, stewardship	Which preservation tools fit each parcel and funding source
EGLE + drain/water authorities	Wetlands, streams, floodplain, stormwater, drainage and permits	Where the corridor must avoid, span, restore, or treat water systems
DNR + Ingham County Parks	Habitat connectivity, recreation, trail and park integration	Where public landscape and wildlife crossings create regional value
CATA + trail planners	Express transit, mobility hubs, trail connectivity and accessibility	What should be reserved now and operated later
Landowners, residents, businesses	Route knowledge, property interests, farm operations, community objectives	What can be preserved, compensated, avoided, or redesigned

A staged decision—not a predetermined project

Stage zero is institutional: define the study area, public purposes, alternatives, decision criteria, and authority for interim corridor preservation. Stage one inventories traffic, parcels, farms, wetlands, hydrology, habitat, cultural resources, existing trails, infrastructure capacity, and community priorities. Stage two tests a no-build alternative, demand management, targeted improvements to existing roads, transit investment, and Greenway corridor variants. Only a preferred planning alternative would advance to environmental review, preliminary engineering, funding, acquisition, and permitting.

A NEW MIDDLE CATEGORY

Beyond “full freeway or nothing”

Michigan’s historic planning culture often treated the freeway as the complete solution and the existing road as the fallback. The 1961 Lansing plan repeatedly proposed conversion to freeway standards and described outer controlled-access routes as the framework for regional growth. When public decisions are repeatedly presented as freeway versus no-build, the vocabulary narrows with them. Many residents understandably use freeway, expressway, highway, and arterial as synonyms because intermediate forms are rarely made legible as durable choices.

Northeast Lower Michigan’s US-23 corridor is a revealing example. After decades of planning a new freeway from Standish toward Tawas and Oscoda, MDOT submitted a final environmental document for the Standish–M-55 segment. In March 2000, FHWA rejected a freeway-or-no-build alternatives structure and requested examination of less elaborate choices, including a boulevard, improvements to existing routes, passing lanes, signals, intersection work, and staged construction.¹⁶¹⁷ In 2002 MDOT accepted the no-build alternative and removed the freeway from its program rather than advancing a coherent intermediate regional corridor.

The mobility and safety questions did not disappear. US-23 remains predominantly a two-lane corridor carrying local, commercial, and seasonal travel through communities along Lake Huron, while MDOT continues to address conflicts through project-by-project reconstruction and lane changes.³¹ The policy failure was not cancellation of the freeway as such; it was failure to carry an intermediate regional strategy through design, environmental review, and funding.

Intermediate does not mean temporary

A super-2, for example, is a two-lane rural highway with periodic passing lanes that allow traffic platoons to disperse. FHWA includes the form in its Safe System design hierarchy, and 2+1 variants alternate the passing direction within a three-lane envelope.³² Other middle forms include access-managed two-lane highways, limited-access boulevards, divided expressways with selected at-grade junctions, and staged corridors with right-of-way protected for later needs. Each can be a complete solution when matched to demand and context.

This criticism should not be read as a claim that present-day MDOT literally recognizes only freeways. The agency now works with access management, multimodal studies, flex routes, context-sensitive design, roundabouts, indirect left turns, and stormwater requirements. The institutional point is that the Capital Region should deliberately define an intermediate typology at the beginning, so inherited categories do not force a false choice between a conventional freeway and unmanaged local-road sprawl.

THE GREENWAY’S MIDDLE CATEGORY

A four-lane divided expressway with legally controlled frontage, selected at-grade civic nodes, grade separation only where justified, multimodal reservation, and conservation commitments adopted as part of the transportation program.

THE FUTURE CONVERSION QUESTION

Not designed for conversion—and not designed against it

Nothing in the physical concept makes later conversion to a fully controlled-access freeway impossible. Such a project would require additional right of way, overpasses, ramps, reconstructed crossings, closure or relocation of at-grade intersections, and renewed treatment of trails, water systems, habitat, farms, and adjoining roads. It would also require new environmental review, funding, design, acquisition, and political authorization. The Greenway does not prebuild, reserve, or promise those elements; its at-grade nodes are intended as permanent features of the expressway, not temporary placeholders.

Michigan history demonstrates that conversion can occur when government chooses it. The US-31 corridor between Niles and Berrien Springs opened in 1992 as a limited-access expressway with no private access but selected at-grade crossroads. Between 1996 and 1998, overpasses and interchanges replaced those crossings and completed its conversion to freeway standards.³⁴ That history establishes physical possibility, not inevitability.

The policy value of convertibility is option rather than trajectory. A functional expressway can meet present needs while later grade separation remains available only if measured demand, safety, and public benefit justify it. Had Michigan used that approach more consistently, some corridors might have operated adequately for decades and never required expensive freeway conversion. That counterfactual cannot be proved, and major Interstate, freight, and metropolitan routes would still have required full control. But it is reasonable to conclude that treating intermediate roads as complete solutions could have avoided or deferred some unnecessary freeway construction.

The objection that the Greenway would be a “freeway in waiting” therefore proves too much. With sufficient public support and investment, other divided or access-managed Michigan corridors—including East Beltline, Old 27, Telegraph Road, and M-37—could also be reconstructed with grade separations and interchanges. Their physical convertibility does not make them undeclared freeway projects. A staged freeway is identified by policy: adopted future-freeway plans, protected interchange envelopes, programmed grade separations, or structures deliberately built for a later phase. This proposal includes none of those commitments.

Public will is the control

What permits or prevents conversion is ultimately public will, expressed through plans, budgets, environmental commitments, conservation easements, right-of-way authorizations, agency decisions, legislation, and elections. No present plan can physically prevent every future government from choosing differently. It can make the current public compact explicit, require any proposed conversion to stand on its own merits, and prevent gradual administrative changes from silently transforming the corridor into something the public never approved.

THE DURABLE PROMISE

The Greenway is not designed as the first phase of a freeway. Neither is it burdened with artificial geometry whose purpose is to make future reconstruction impossible. It remains an expressway because selected permeability, protected land, and multimodal use are adopted public purposes. Converting it would be a new project requiring a new public decision.

THE GREENWAY PROOF STANDARD

A middle category still has to prove itself

Calling the Greenway an intermediate solution cannot become a way to escape rigorous comparison. The study must disclose its assumptions, compare the full system against credible lower-cost alternatives, and evaluate the transportation facility and preservation framework together. A road that survives while its land, water, transit, or stewardship commitments disappear is not a reduced version of the Greenway; it is a different project.

MOBILITY	Does the concept materially improve reliability, safety, freight movement, and network resilience compared with lower-cost alternatives?
DEMAND	Does total vehicle travel and development response remain within adopted performance bounds, rather than merely shifting congestion?
LAND	Are conservation, access, and node rules binding before construction and durable after leadership changes?
ENVIRONMENT	Does the preferred alternative avoid and minimize impacts, improve water treatment, and preserve or restore habitat connectivity?
EQUITY	Are burdens, benefits, acquisition, access, and participation distributed through a legitimate process informed by the I-496 history?
FISCAL	Do lifecycle costs—including local service obligations and landscape stewardship—remain supportable without relying on endless outward growth?

Use the standard as a decision gate

ADVANCE	Benefits remain material after uncertainty testing, and the access, preservation, funding, and governance commitments are enforceable.
REVISE	The public purposes remain plausible, but the route, section, crossing pattern, land program, or operating concept does not yet meet the standard.
PAUSE	Parcel fragmentation or infrastructure extension is accelerating while the legal, financial, or institutional preservation framework remains unresolved.
STOP	The roadway depends on speculative growth, fails a credible alternative comparison, or proceeds after the integrated conservation and multimodal program has been stripped away.

The proof standard should remain visible after any opening day. Baseline and post-opening reports should track travel time, crashes, vehicle miles traveled, mode share, conserved acreage, parcel fragmentation, node development, water performance, habitat connectivity, and local service costs. If results diverge from adopted bounds, the response should begin with access, operations, land use, transit, and demand management—not automatic widening.

RECOMMENDATION

Preserve the option; study the system**RECOMMENDED PUBLIC ACTION**

Commission a regional Eastern Growth Edge and Mobility Study with authority to evaluate corridor preservation, land-use commitments, conservation finance, multimodal alternatives, and a limited-access Greenway concept.

The immediate risk is not that the region will fail to pour concrete soon enough. It is that parcel fragmentation, uncoordinated subdivision, and infrastructure extension will eliminate the ability to choose an integrated solution at all. A study should therefore begin with preservation options and temporary policy safeguards while remaining genuinely open to a no-build outcome.

Required study products

The study should produce a verified constraints and ownership atlas; a travel-market and induced-demand analysis; alternatives that include no-build, existing-road, transit, and Greenway variants; a conservation and agricultural-economy plan; a node and infrastructure-boundary framework; a trail and transit integration plan; a water and habitat connectivity plan; an authority and governance memorandum; lifecycle cost ranges; and a transparent evaluation matrix.

Conditions before a preferred corridor

No alternative should be advanced unless participating governments are prepared to adopt enforceable access and land-use commitments, identify a credible conservation steward, fund long-term landscape maintenance, and measure outcomes after opening. The Greenway's public purpose is the integrated result. If the preservation and governance components are stripped away, the road component should not proceed under this name.

Why this belongs in the Capital Region

Greater Lansing still has an unusual opportunity: a substantial regional trail culture, strong public institutions, an intact eastern agricultural landscape, and a transportation network whose unfinished geometry remains legible. The region can use that inheritance to repeat a freeway-era pattern—or to create a corridor that protects the very landscape and communities it is meant to serve.

SEPARATION WITHOUT RUPTURE.

MOBILITY WITHOUT SPRAWL.

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Scope and authorship

This white paper is an independent conceptual work product prepared by David Towne for Cognisint LLC. It consolidates a developing regional-planning concept and identifies questions for professional study. It does not represent the position of MDOT, FHWA, any county, township, city, agency, landowner, railroad, or conservation organization. References to route forms, intersection treatments, dimensions, speeds, crossings, or public powers are illustrative and require validation by qualified professionals and public bodies.

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